

The Misprint File

The Misprint File

A Novel

[Author's Name]

[Publisher Name]

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The Misprint File

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Published by [PUBLISHER]

[PUBLISHER ADDRESS]

ISBN: [ISBN] (Hardcover) | [ISBN] (Paperback) | [ISBN] (eBook)

First Edition: [YEAR]

Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication Data

Names: [AUTHOR NAME]

Title: The Misprint File / [AUTHOR NAME]

Description: First edition. | [PUBLISHER], [YEAR] | Includes bibliographical references and index (if applicable).

Identifiers: LCCN [LCCN NUMBER] | ISBN [ISBN] (hardcover) | ISBN [ISBN] (paperback) | ISBN [ISBN] (ebook)

Subjects: LCSH: Dystopian fiction. | Noir fiction. | Bureaucracy—Fiction. | Fate and fatalism—Fiction. | Immortality—Fiction.

Classification: LCC [LCC NUMBER] | DDC [DDC NUMBER]

LC record available at [https://lcn.loc.gov/\[LCCN NUMBER\]](https://lcn.loc.gov/[LCCN NUMBER])

Printed in the United States of America

10 9 8 7 6 5 4 3 2 1

Dedication

To the ones who opened the wrong envelope and never looked back—
and to every data point that refused to compute.

“A blank date is not a flaw in the system. It is a flaw in the object. The envelope contains the truth; the truth is not always contained by the envelope.”

— *Fatal Affairs Bureau, Internal Protocol Memo §17.4b*
(Classified)

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Chapter 1 — The Blank Envelope

The morning mail cart clattered down Hamlin Terrace in the Waterstone district, its iron casters grinding against pavement that had not been repaired since before the Bureau assumed oversight of municipal maintenance. Lena Voss pushed the cart with the precise, two-handed grip mandated by the Fatal Affairs Postal Codex, and she never took her eyes off the house numbers because misdelivery was a misdemeanor and she had been a carrier for only eleven weeks.

She wore the pressed blue uniform, the cap with the Bureau's emblem—an envelope bisected by a single vertical line, the universal symbol for certainty—and the satchel containing the day's primary deliveries: forty-seven death-date envelopes, each sealed in cream-colored vellum with a wax closure that required the recipient's thumbprint for verification. The envelopes were small, barely larger than a thank-you card, because the message inside required only ten digits. A date. Nothing more.

At 47 Hamlin Terrace, a man answered the door before she could knock. He had the hollow eyes of someone who had not slept, and he held an infant against his chest, the baby wrapped in a white receiving blanket that still bore the creases from its packaging.

"Carrier Voss, Route 1103," Lena said, reciting the script from memory. "I have a sealed directive from the Fatal Affairs Bureau, to be delivered to the designated recipient, citizen number 849-726-011-DF, born at Mount Mercy Medical at four-oh-two this morning."

The man extended his free hand, fingers already positioned for the thumbprint pad.

“You don’t have to read it now,” Lena added, because the script allowed it, and because she had seen too many parents hold their breath while the envelope’s inner slip was withdrawn. “The Bureau recommends private reflection.”

“I know the procedure.” The man pressed his thumb to the pad on her handheld, and the device beeped confirmation. She handed him the envelope. He took it with the same hand, his grip tightening around the edge, and he did not look down at it. “My wife’s already at the Bureau, requesting a look-ahead.”

Lena said nothing. Look-ahead petitions were common in the first twenty-four hours—parents seeking a glimpse of their child’s assigned date, in hopes of finding a late-century number that meant the child would outlive them. The Bureau granted less than two percent of these petitions, and only after a battery of psychological evaluations and form submissions: 11-C, 11-D, the supplemental attachment for “anticipatory grief mitigation.” Most parents never saw inside the envelope until the child was old enough to request it themselves, which the Bureau permitted at age sixteen, provided the citizen submitted a Form 12-A and paid the processing fee.

Lena recorded the delivery in her handheld, then moved to the next house. By the time she reached the end of Hamlin Terrace, she had delivered nine envelopes and collected nineteen thumbprints—the extra ten from adults who had received their own envelopes at birth and now lived their lives around a known terminus. She passed a

woman in a kerchief who was scrubbing her front steps, and without prompting, the woman said, “Twenty-one years, four months, eleven days,” and smiled as if she had recited the winning numbers in a lottery.

The public loved the system. Lena had learned this early in training, when the orientation instructor—a man named Garvey who had been with the Bureau for three decades and wore his own end-date on a bracelet around his wrist—had explained the principle of “temporal certainty.”

“Before the Algorithm, people lived in ignorance,” Garvey had said, standing before a projection that displayed actuarial charts and census data. “They saved too little or too much. They married the wrong people. They postponed joy because they assumed they had more time than they did, or they rushed into misery because they assumed they had less. The Bureau solved chaos. Every citizen now has a fixed horizon, and within that horizon, they are free.”

What Garvey did not say, and what Lena only later understood, was that the freedom was circumscribed by a thousand small enforcements. The date in your envelope determined your loan eligibility, your insurance premiums, your career track. It determined whether you could emigrate or reproduce or serve on a jury. A citizen with an early date—anything before fifty-five—was considered a “short-term resource” and assigned to high-risk, high-output labor because the Bureau’s logic held that their productive window was limited. A citizen with a date past eighty was treated as a long-term investment, entitled to advanced education, deferred compensation, and positions of authority. The Algorithm was never wrong, so the assignments were

never unfair.

Lena's own envelope had been delivered to her parents twenty-six years ago, on the morning of her birth. She had not opened it. She had never wanted to open it. The Bureau allowed citizens to request a sealed copy at any time, but most people carried their dates with them, memorized like a phone number. Lena preferred the silence. Her plan was to stay a carrier, follow the route, and let the date find her when it was ready.

By 10:47 a.m., she had cleared her deliveries for Waterstone and pushed the empty cart back to the district distribution hub, a low-slung concrete building with grated windows and a sign above the door that read: Fatal Affairs Bureau — Municipal Holding. Security cameras tracked her movement across the parking lot. Inside, the fluorescent lights buzzed at a frequency that always made her molars ache.

She clocked out for the day's first shift using the wall-mounted terminal, then walked to the break room to retrieve her lunch from the locker. The break room was empty except for a senior carrier named Olds, who sat at the corner table sorting his proof-of-delivery receipts and muttering about a new regulation that required carriers to re-verify their own death-date registrations every fiscal quarter.

"It's a mess," Olds said without looking up. "They're pulling everyone's master files. Something about a discrepancy in the sorting algorithm. I had to go down to Records this morning and request my own birth envelope."

Lena paused with her hand on her locker. "I thought the master files were sealed."

“They are. But the Bureau has the right to examine them for quality assurance. You got yours, don’t you? You’ll have to do the same thing. Mandatory verification. They’ll call you down when it’s your turn.” Olds shook a receipt at her. “Better to go voluntarily. Looks proactive.”

Eleven weeks on the job, and she had already learned that “proactive” was the Bureau’s favorite adjective. Proactive carriers were promoted. Proactive carriers were not placed on performance improvement plans. Proactive carriers did not attract the attention of the Auditors.

She ate her lunch—a nutritionally balanced meal bar issued by the Bureau’s wellness division—then walked to the Records office on the building’s third floor. The hallway there was quieter than the rest of the hub, with thicker carpet and a reception desk staffed by a clerk who moved with deliberate, bureaucratic slowness. Behind the clerk, rows of filing cabinets stretched into the darkness, each drawer locked and numbered according to a system that Lena had never learned.

“Carrier Voss,” she said. “I’m here for a master file retrieval. Birth envelope.”

The clerk typed something into her terminal, squinted at the screen, and typed again. “Reason?”

“Proactive verification.”

The clerk made a note of that, then printed a Form 9-G—the internal request slip—and handed it to her. “Sign here. The file will be pulled within the hour. You can wait in the reading room.”

The reading room was a small cubicle with a single desk, a chair, and a box of tissues. Lena had never been inside one before, and she did not

like how the walls seemed to lean inward, or how the light was angled to cast the desk in pale, clinical brightness. She sat and waited. The hour passed in silence, broken only by the distant hum of the building's systems.

At exactly sixty-two minutes after her request, the door opened and the clerk entered, carrying a sealed envelope. The wax closure was original, stamped with the Bureau's emblem and the date of Lena's birth. The envelope was smaller than the ones she delivered—older stock, slightly yellowed at the edges—and when the clerk placed it on the desk, Lena felt something cold move through her chest.

"Master file retrieval is complete," the clerk said. "You are authorized to open and review the contents for the purpose of employment verification. Do you understand that any alteration or destruction of Bureau property is a federal offense?"

"I understand."

The clerk handed her a letter opener with the Bureau's logo on the handle, then stepped back and folded her hands, waiting.

Lena broke the wax seal with one careful motion. The envelope opened along the top edge, and she withdrew the single slip of paper inside. It was cream-colored, the same stock as the vellum, and it bore the Bureau's watermark: a faint, repeating pattern of envelopes, each one crossed by the vertical line.

The slip was blank.

There were no numbers. No date. No ink at all. The paper was smooth and untouched, as if the Algorithm had never touched it, as if the

Bureau's prediction had been withheld or erased or never made.

Lena stared at the paper for a long moment. Her training had covered dozens of anomalous scenarios—stolen envelopes, forged dates, water damage—but she had never been told what to do if the date was missing. She had never heard of a date being missing. The Algorithm was perfect. Everyone had a date. Everyone.

She turned the paper over. The back was blank.

“Carrier Voss?” the clerk said. “Do you require assistance?”

Lena's voice came out flat and distant, someone else's voice. “This is my file? This is the original?”

“Yes, ma'am. Pulled from the vault directly.”

“There's nothing on it.”

The clerk leaned forward, her expression shifting from bureaucratic patience to something sharper. “That's not possible. The Algorithm does not produce blanks.”

Lena held up the slip, and the clerk went very still.

In the silence that followed, Lena heard something that was not silence: a low, electronic tone, three ascending notes, repeating. It came from the clerk's terminal, and from the hallway beyond, and from the speakers embedded in the ceiling, a tone that she had never heard before but recognized immediately from the training videos. It was the Misprint Alert. The sound the system made when it detected an error in the Algorithm's output.

The clerk backed toward the door. “Stay here. Do not move. Do not touch anything else.”

She was gone before Lena could answer.

The reading room shrank around her. Lena sat with the blank slip in her hand and the alert tone drilling itself into her skull, and she thought about all the forms she had signed in training, all the regulations she had memorized, all the times she had reassured citizens that the Bureau was infallible, that the Algorithm was never wrong. The paper in her hand was not infallible. It was a void, a silence where her death should have been, and the Bureau was already screaming about it.

She did not have to wait long. Within five minutes—she counted the seconds on the wall clock—the door opened again, and two security officers entered, both wearing the gray-and-black uniform of Internal Affairs. They did not speak to her. One of them took the slip from her hand, sealed it in an evidence bag, and left the room without a word. The other officer gestured for her to stand and follow.

They took her through a series of corridors that she had never seen, despite working in the hub for nearly three months. The walls were painted a darker shade of gray, and the doors they passed had no names, only numbers, and each one was equipped with a thumbprint scanner that the officer had to use before they could proceed. At the end of the hall, they stopped before a door labeled: Misprint Division — Director’s Office.

The officer knocked once. A voice from inside said, “Send her in.”

Lena stepped through the door alone.

Director Wen sat behind a desk that was entirely bare except for an ink pad, a brass stamp, and a single sheet of paper—Lena’s birth envelope slip, now contained within a transparent evidence sleeve. Wen was a woman in her fifties, with iron-gray hair pulled back into a tight bun and the bearing of someone who had not been surprised by anything in decades. She wore the standard Bureau suit, but the pin on her lapel was not the standard envelope emblem. It was the same envelope, except the vertical line was broken, split in half, the symbol of the Misprint Division.

“Sit down, Carrier Voss,” Wen said. “We have a limited amount of time before the Auditor claims jurisdiction, and I would prefer to have this conversation before he arrives.”

Lena sat. Her hands were cold, and she pressed them against her thighs to keep them still. “I don’t understand what’s happening.”

“You are a misprint. The Algorithm produced a null output for your death-date, which means you were never assigned a terminus. As of this moment, you are technically outside the system. You cannot die of natural causes. You cannot be killed by conventional means. The Bureau has no record of how your timeline ends.” Wen tapped the evidence sleeve with her index finger. “This makes you an anomaly, and anomalies are not tolerated.”

The word registered from somewhere deep in Lena’s training: *misprint*. It was a myth, a catch-all for any deviation from the Algorithm’s output—stolen envelopes, clerical errors, the rare but unverified rumor of someone who had faked their own prediction. In the official narrative, misprints did not exist. The Bureau had corrected every

error. The Algorithm was infallible.

“You’re wrong,” Lena said. “This has to be a mistake. A delivery error. Maybe my envelope was damaged in transit, or the ink—”

“The ink is embedded into the paper fiber at manufacture. It cannot fade, cannot be removed, cannot be altered. We examined the slip while you were en route. It was never printed. The Algorithm skipped your file entirely.” Wen’s gaze did not waver. “This has happened before, Carrier Voss. Not often. But enough that we have protocols.”

Lena felt the room shift, the floor tilting under her. The blank paper, the alarm, the security officers—it was all moving too fast, a machinery of dread that she could not outrun. “What protocols?”

“Correction. The Misprint Division exists to repair errors in the Algorithm’s output. For a blank date like yours, the standard correction is a reprint: we assign you a new death-date, and once the date is assigned, the error is resolved.”

“Reprint a date?” Lena’s voice rose. “You can just—assign me a death?”

“We can. The process is called reprinting, and it returns a misprint to the system. Once you have a date, you are subject to its terms. You become mortal again, and your life resumes its proper trajectory.” Wen paused. “However, reprinting is not my first recommendation.”

Lena waited. She could hear, faintly through the door, the sound of footsteps approaching—brisk, purposeful, and growing louder.

“The Bureau has another program,” Wen continued. “A more efficient use of your current status. You are functionally immortal, which makes you an ideal asset for locating and retrieving other misprints. Broken daters, we call them—individuals whose predictions have been corrupted or altered in some way that renders them similarly immune to death. They defect from the system. They hide. They build networks outside the Bureau’s authority, spreading instability and questioning the Algorithm’s integrity.”

The footsteps had stopped outside the door.

Wen leaned forward, her eyes hard and patient. “I am offering you a choice, Carrier Voss. Join the Misprint Division as a hunter, locate the broken daters who threaten the system’s order, and your blank date remains untouched. You will live indefinitely, so long as you serve. Refuse, and I will authorize the reprint, assign you a date within the year, and close your file before midnight.”

The door opened behind Lena. She did not turn to look. She knew, with the certainty of a woman who had spent her life trusting the system, that Auditor Ambrose Marchetti was behind her, and that his presence meant the offer had an expiration date.

“One minute,” Wen said. “Decide.”

Lena looked at the blank slip inside its evidence sleeve, at the absence where her death should have been, and she thought about the man on Hamlin Terrace who had held his infant and refused to open the envelope. She thought about the woman who had counted down her remaining years like a prize. She thought about her own parents, who had never asked to see inside hers, and about the silence she had

carried all her life, assuming that somewhere there was a date waiting for her.

Now there was nothing. And nothing, she understood, was the most dangerous thing the Bureau could find.

“I’ll join,” Lena said.

Director Wen did not smile. She picked up the brass stamp from her desk, pressed it to the ink pad, and stamped the corner of Lena’s employee file, which had appeared on her desk as if by bureaucratic magic. The stamp left a broken-envelope mark, the same as Wen’s lapel pin.

“Report to Processing at oh-six-hundred tomorrow,” Wen said. “Auditor Marchetti will escort you home and secure your quarters. From this moment, you are property of the Misprint Division.”

Lena turned. The Auditor stood in the doorway, a tall man in a black suit with a face like a locked file cabinet, and his eyes were already cataloging her as a problem to solve. He held a tablet open to a screen she could not read, but she could guess what it said: her name, her blank slip, and a form number she would soon learn by heart.

“Carrier Voss,” Marchetti said, and his voice was tired and exact. “Let’s go.”

She followed him into the gray corridor, past the numbered doors and the security cameras and the hum of the Bureau’s endless sorting, and she walked with the weight of a new truth pressing against her ribs: she was indelible now, a glitch with a pulse, and the system would never stop trying to reprint her.

Chapter 2 — The Hunter and the Hunted

Processing at 0600 was Processing at any hour—sterile light, the hum of ventilation, the smell of disinfectant over old paper. Lena Voss arrived in a gray uniform that still smelled of the plastic she'd peeled it from. The Misprint Division's broken-envelope pin sat on her collar, cold and weightless as a lie.

A handler named Pryce met her in a room that had been stripped of anything you could call furniture except a metal table and two chairs. Pryce had the kind of posture that suggested he'd been stamped out of cheap steel. He didn't ask her to sit.

"You're not an agent," he said. "You're a retrieval instrument. You follow the protocol, you report every deviation, and you wait for authorization. If the subject resists, you do not engage. You call for the containment team. The Bureau invested in your blank date, and we don't waste investments."

He slid a flat case across the table. Inside, nested in foam: a locator the size of a pocket ledger, its screen dark; a slim injector with a preloaded cartridge of sedative, fifteen milliliters; a laminated card of emergency codes. The locator, Pryce explained, synced with the Bureau's postal-intelligence matrix. Every misprint left a trail—forwarding addresses, utility payments, a worried aunt's letter that got flagged because the recipient's death-date predated the postmark. The hunter's job was not to fight. It was to find, confirm, and contain.

"You'll have an analyst on the line," Pryce added. "Their word is procedure."

Behind him, against the far wall, Auditor Ambrose Marchetti stood without speaking. His black suit absorbed the light, and his face was a shuttered storefront after curfew. Lena felt his attention like a thumb on her file. She didn't look at him directly.

The orientation film played for ninety minutes in a cubicle the size of a broom closet. A calm voice explained that misprints were statistical anomalies that, left uncorrected, eroded the public's faith in the Algorithm. The images showed smiling citizens, open envelopes, tidy rows of dates. When the film ended, Lena's reflection in the blank screen looked hollow.

By 0830 she was seated beside an analyst in a cramped operations cell. The analyst, a woman whose badge read "S. Voss"—no relation, the universe's little cruelty—pulled up a file. The subject was Elias Sander, age thirty-four, former Bureau courier. His prediction had fractured during a rail-yard accident three years ago; he'd walked away from a collision that should have crushed his spine, and the internal audit triggered a misprint flag. The Bureau issued a recall for reprinting. Sander fled. His file had been officially closed with a terminal notation, and a death certificate was released to his next of kin. Standard procedure for maintaining public certainty.

"His mother believes he died in the accident," S. Voss said, scrolling through the file without inflection. "The address is in your dossier. Under no circumstances do you correct that impression. You are conducting a routine re-verification of death-date registrations. Use your carrier credentials if questioned."

Lena's mouth went dry. She thought of the man at 47 Hamlin Terrace, the infant in the white blanket, the thumbprint pressed to paper. She had delivered that child's death-date without a second thought.

"Understood," she said.

The locator chimed softly as it synced to her thumbprint. Its screen flickered with a street map of the River District, a red dot pulsing at the address of Sander's mother. The trail was cold, the analyst explained, but the system had intercepted an envelope addressed to a woman named Halstrom—mother's maiden name—that contained no message, only a single digit written on the flap. A signal. Probably a meet. The Bureau wanted Lena to intercept any contact.

She rode a public transport to the district, the locator heavy in her coat pocket. The morning light was gray and indifferent. Apartment block forty-three smelled of boiled cabbage and rust. Mrs. Halstrom opened her door with the chain still on, a woman in her sixties with creased eyes and a faded kerchief. Lena showed her postal badge and recited the script: a random verification check, just procedure, had she received any irregular mail recently? The woman's face tightened.

"My son is dead," she said. "Two years. What sort of verification do you need for the dead?"

Lena's throat constricted. The protocol didn't cover this. She said, "We're updating the master files. Sometimes cross-references throw up old names. I'm sorry to disturb you."

The door closed, and Lena stood in the hallway, breathing through the tightness in her chest. The locator remained silent. No contact made.

She reported the negative result to the analyst, who told her to wait in the area and monitor. That was the Bureau's speed: waiting in a stairwell for a ghost.

Three hours later, the locator pulsed. A message had been left on a public message board at a laundromat four blocks away—a number sequence that matched Sander's known ciphers. The analyst triangulated the drop point to a tenement on Meridian Row. Lena walked there through a light rain, her wet shoes squeaking on the linoleum stairs of a building half condemned. The apartment she found was empty but recently occupied: a mattress without sheets, an electric coil still warm, a half-burned envelope in the sink. The envelope bore no address, just a scrawl—a subway access code.

She called it in. The analyst authorized her to proceed to the tunnel entrance and wait for a containment team. Protocol. Always wait.

The tunnel entrance was a rusted door at the back of an abandoned platform, the lock already broken. Lena pushed inside. The air was damp and cold, carrying the distant drip of water and the faint mineral smell of old concrete. She walked slowly, the locator held out like a candle. Its screen flickered—SIGNAL DEGRADED—but the analyst's voice over the earpiece told her to continue. The misprint's transponder tag had pinged in this sector.

She heard movement before she saw anything. A scuff of shoe on gravel, a breath exhaled fast in the dark. Lena stopped. The locator's screen pulsed one bright dot, then dissolved into static. The analyst's voice broke up. Lena called out, "Elias Sander, this is the Fatal Affairs Bureau. You are required to submit for reprinting. Compliance will be

noted.”

A figure broke from the shadows—a lanky man in a worn coat, moving not with athletic grace but with the desperate lurch of someone who’d been running for years. Lena took a step forward, her shoe slipping on the wet floor, and by the time she steadied herself the man had vanished around a bend. She hurried after him, the locator dead in her hand, the earpiece silent. The tunnel split, and she chose left, her heart hammering, then stopped. A dead end. A service grate, locked. She could hear him somewhere ahead, the sounds receding, and she knew she had lost him.

Then a voice came from behind her, calm and soft: “You’re new at this.”

Lena spun. The man who stood there was not Sander. He was shorter, wiry, with a face that had learned to smile around the fear. He wore a patched canvas jacket and held his hands open, empty. His eyes flicked to her collar pin—the broken envelope—and his smile widened just slightly.

“That thing you’re carrying won’t work here,” he said, nodding at the locator. “We’ve got a jammer. Crude, but effective. The Bureau thinks we’re static.”

Lena’s training rose up in her. “Identify yourself. You’re obstructing a retrieval operation.”

“I’m Oscar Kole,” he said, as if the name should mean something. “And you’re Lena Voss. We’ve been watching your file circulate. Blank like us. Except you took their collar instead of running.”

He stepped closer, and Lena's hand went to the injector in her pocket. Kole didn't flinch.

"You can use that if you want," he said. "It won't change anything. They'll reprint you the second you stop being useful. Maybe you'll get a nice long date—five years, ten—but you'll get one. I've seen the records. We all have."

"Sander," Lena said. "Where is he?"

"Gone. You'll never find him. Not today. The Bureau's procedures are a sieve if you know how to move." He tilted his head. "You followed the rules to the letter, and you still lost him. Think about that."

From somewhere deep in the tunnels, a distant clang echoed—the containment team arriving, too late. Kole reached into his jacket and withdrew a simple business card, nothing on it but a ten-digit number. He held it out.

"When you're ready to stop being a retrieval instrument," he said. "You'll be less lonely than you are now."

Lena didn't take it. She kept her hand on the injector, her mind a scramble of protocol and fear. Kole placed the card on a ledge of broken concrete, then stepped backward into the dark. By the time she thought to move, he was gone.

The containment team found her standing alone, the locator rebooting in her hand with a flat electronic tone and a red message: TARGET LOST. Marchetti arrived minutes later, his footsteps deliberate, his expression unreadable. He swept his flashlight over the tunnel, the grate, the ledge where the card had been. Lena had already pocketed it

without quite knowing why.

“What happened?” Marchetti asked. His voice was a file drawer closing.

“The signal degraded,” Lena said. “I lost him. Then another man approached me. He said his name was Oscar Kole. He told me I was a tool and walked away before I could detain him.”

“Did he offer you anything?”

Lena’s fingers brushed the card in her pocket. She thought of the envelope in Mrs. Halstrom’s sink, the lie the Bureau had told a mother, the way Sander had run like a man who had already been buried. She met Marchetti’s eyes.

“No,” she said. “Nothing.”

Marchetti held her gaze for a long moment, then made a note in his tablet. “You followed procedure, Voss. That’s all we ask. The next target will be better prepared.”

He turned and walked back up the tunnel, and Lena followed, the card a small sharp corner against her thigh.

That night, in her apartment, she sat on the edge of her mattress and pulled out the card. It was plain white stock, the number printed in a standard sans-serif font. She turned it over. Blank. The locator sat on her nightstand, deactivated, its screen a dead gray eye.

She didn’t call. She didn’t burn it. She placed it in the empty drawer of her nightstand and closed it, then lay awake in the dark, listening to the hum of the city’s certainty, trying to remember a time when a number

had felt like safety.

Chapter 3 — The Reprint Protocol

The summons came not as a ping on the locator but as two Internal Affairs officers at her door ten minutes before dawn. No words, no warrant—just the heavy gray-and-black presence of them, filling the threshold like a misplaced filing cabinet. Lena had been pulling on her uniform jacket when the knock landed, and the half-buttoned collar felt suddenly like a noose.

“You’ll come with us,” the taller one said. A statement, not a question. His partner’s hand rested on the butt of a stun baton, fingers drumming a silent countdown.

She didn’t ask why. She’d learned that much in the Misprint Division: questions were admissions of ignorance, and ignorance was guilt. She stepped into the corridor, and they flanked her down the stairwell, past the bank of postal boxes where, only weeks ago, she’d delivered envelopes stamped with other people’s certainties. The air tasted of recycled dust and old paper.

The transport was a windowless van with a partitioned rear cage. They drove for forty minutes, the vehicle’s suspension groaning over the city’s rusted infrastructure. When the doors opened again, they were in a district she didn’t recognize—industrial, low-ceilinged, lit by humming fluorescent tubes that buzzed at a frequency just below headache. The sign above the entrance read **BUREAU CORRECTIONS ANNEX – SECTOR 7**, its enamel cracked like ancient skin.

Inside, the corridors narrowed into a bureaucratic labyrinth. They passed a bulletin board crusted with faded notices: shift rotations, wellness-bar inventory counts, a mandatory posting about posture at workstations. And beside it, in a glass-fronted frame, a safety poster she almost missed. **REPRINT PRESS MODEL 4-C: OPERATIONAL SAFETY PROTOCOLS.** A diagram of the machine in cutaway view, arrows pointing to its components: feed tray, embossing die, thumb-plate reader, restraint chair, holding pod interface. And at the bottom, in bold red ink: **IN EVENT OF PAPER JAM OR FEED FAILURE, ALL RESTRAINTS DISENGAGE. EMERGENCY MAINTENANCE MODE RELEASES POD DOORS. AUTHORIZED TECHNICIANS ONLY.** She filed the information without breaking stride, the way a carrier memorizes a route hazard.

The officers deposited her in a small waiting room with a single chair bolted to the floor and one flickering light. She sat for twenty-three minutes by her own internal count, the numbers ticking in her head like a second heartbeat. Then the door opened, and Auditor Ambrose Marchetti entered, carrying a black dossier and a face that was not a locked file cabinet this time but something older—a vault with a seized mechanism, rusted around the edges but still impenetrable.

He set the dossier on a narrow shelf and removed a clear evidence sleeve. Inside it lay a familiar slip of paper, smaller than a palm, empty of ink.

“Your original birth slip,” Marchetti said. “Requisitioned from the evidence locker. I thought it appropriate that you see it before we proceed.”

Lena kept her expression neutral, though her stomach had turned to cold sludge. “Proceed with what?”

“Your reprint. The Commissioner’s office issued the order at oh-four-hundred this morning, after we linked your locator signature to the signal jammer used by Oscar Kole’s network. We’d been sweeping the cells all night. Kole was apprehended at midnight, along with four other unregistered misprints. You were observed meeting with him in the tunnel. You withheld that contact during debriefing. The Commissioner considers that collaboration.”

She felt the room narrow. The locator. She hadn’t realized it could be read even when jammed—or perhaps the jamming itself had left a gap in the signal matrix, a silence as loud as a scream. “Director Wen gave me my assignment. She knows I was approached.”

“Director Wen signed off on your field clearance, yes. But the reprint authorization comes from higher up. The Bureau’s patience with her hunter program has limits when assets go dark. You are now a liability.” He paused, letting the word settle. “However, the Commissioner has offered a conditional stay.”

Lena waited. She’d learned that silence was a weapon when you had nothing left to barter.

“You will personally initiate the reprinting of Oscar Kole. Your thumb, your print command. Once he has been restored to the Algorithm—given a new terminus—your misprint file will be sealed permanently, and your blank status will remain intact. You will continue as a retrieval instrument, under tighter supervision. Refuse, and you will be reprinted within the hour. A date, very close. Perhaps

seventy-two hours. Perhaps less. Choose.”

He held out the evidence sleeve. “Prove your loyalty, and this slip will be destroyed. You’ll never have to wonder again.”

A muscle twitched beneath her eye. She could see the trap clearly: Marchetti wanted her to press the button, to become the tool in the same machine that had already marked misprints for elimination. But the alternative was her own reprint—a date that would strangle the rest of her life into a countdown she’d seen break people since childhood. She thought of the new father at 47 Hamlin Terrace, thumbprinting for his infant’s envelope, already mortgaging a future that had a set number of days. She’d been that infant once. Blank, but blank meant nothing to her then. Now, it was a kind of air.

“I want to see the order,” she said, her voice steadier than she felt. “And the Commissioner’s signature.”

Marchetti’s jaw tightened. “The Commissioner does not—”

“I’m a misprint. I’m already a statistical anomaly. If you’re going to reprint me, you can damn well show me the paperwork.”

The absurdity of her request hung in the air, and for a moment, bureaucracy hesitated. Then, with the slow deliberation of a man forced to obey his own rules, Marchetti unclasped the dossier and withdrew a single sheet bearing the Bureau’s seal—an envelope bisected by a vertical line—and beneath it, two signatures: the Commissioner’s scrawl, and a stamped approval from the Office of Temporal Compliance. No Wen. The system, closing its own loophole.

“Satisfied?” Marchetti asked.

She was not. But she nodded, memorizing the stamp's code number in the same way she'd memorized delivery routes. "Take me to the machine."

The reprint chamber occupied the annex's basement level, a windowless room with reinforced walls and a floor gridded with drainage channels that smelled faintly of disinfectant and ozone. The centerpiece was the press itself: a hulking construct of stainless steel and industrial plastic, its throat open to expose the feed tray loaded with a neat stack of blank slips, the thumb plate gleaming under a dedicated spotlight, an embossing die poised like a guillotine's cousin, and a screen that displayed a quiet amber prompt: **READY – AWAITING SUBJECT INPUT**. A restraint chair stood before it, padded cuffs hanging slack. Against the far wall, a transparent holding pod hummed, its interior divided into three narrow compartments. Two of those compartments held occupants now—a thin man with spectacles and a woman whose shaved head caught the harsh light—both motionless, as if conserving their terror. Nearby, Oscar Kole knelt on the floor, hands bound behind his back, a bruise flowering along his jaw, his canvas jacket torn at the shoulder. Two containment officers stood over him.

Marchetti signaled, and the officers dragged Kole to a metal ring set into the wall, chaining him there with a short tether so he was forced to watch. Kole's eyes found Lena's. There was no accusation in them, only a weary recognition. "They rolled up the network at midnight," he said, his voice hoarse. "Someone talked. Wasn't you, though. You didn't even dial the number."

She didn't answer. She couldn't afford to, with Marchetti studying her like a lab report. The Auditor stepped to the control lectern. "We'll begin with the demonstration. Protocol requires that any candidate for conditional reinstatement witness the reprint process firsthand—to understand the gravity of what we restore."

The first misprint was a woman in her fifties, brought in from a side corridor by a handler in gray coveralls. She flinched at the sight of the machine, her thin hands grasping at the air as if she could hold onto the minutes she had left. "Please," she whispered. "I didn't ask for this. My date just—broke. I never tried to run."

"You were born null," Marchetti said, reading from a tablet. "You've lived forty-seven years outside the Algorithm's certainty. That ends now. The Bureau assigns a new terminus. In your case, cardiac infarction. Natural. Clean. You have seventy-two hours remaining. Use them well."

The handler guided the woman into the restraint chair. Cuffs closed over her wrists and ankles. Marchetti placed his own thumb on the plate—a supervisor override, Lena noted—then instructed the handler to feed a blank slip into the tray. The machine hummed, a low vibration that threaded through the floor. The screen flickered: **PROCESSING... NEW DATE ASSIGNED: 72:00:00**. The embossing die descended, pressing ink into fiber with a soft hiss. A freshly printed slip emerged from a slot, its ten-digit number stamped in indelible black.

The woman did not scream. She simply sagged, a quiet exhalation that was more grief than breath. The handler released the cuffs and led her

toward the holding pod, where the thin man and the shaved-head woman watched through the glass. The pod's other compartment—the one meant for her—was ready, but instead, the handler redirected her to a solid metal door on the opposite wall, marked **DETENTION**. She would live her seventy-two hours in a cell, counting down.

Lena's throat closed. No injection. No poison. Just the certainty of a date, issued like a parking ticket, and the slow, grinding wait for the Algorithm to make good on its math. It was more obscene than a bullet.

The second subject was a young man, barely out of adolescence, his cheeks still smooth with the last remnants of baby fat. He received a week—pulmonary failure—and left the chair with a blank expression, already dead behind the eyes. The machine whirled through its cycle again, impersonal as a mail sorter.

Marchetti turned to Lena. "Now. Your decision. Oscar Kole is the last active misprint to be processed. You will activate the reprint. Place your thumb on the reader. The tray is loaded. Press the stud, and his new date will be printed. Do it, and your file is sealed."

The officers unshackled Kole from the ring and hauled him to the restraint chair. He didn't resist, but he looked at Lena with something that might have been hope or might have been a final test. "You know what this machine really prints," he said. "It's not a date. It's a permission slip for the Bureau to keep pretending the Algorithm never breaks."

Lena stepped toward the lectern. Her shoes made no sound on the grated floor. Her reflection stared back at her from the polished metal

housing of the press—a woman in a gray uniform, a broken-envelope pin at her collar, her face a mask worn thin. She placed her right hand on the thumb plate, feeling the cool glass under her skin. The amber prompt shifted to green. **AUTHORIZED USER: VOSS, L. INITIATION STANDBY.**

The feed tray sat inches from her left hand, that neat stack of blank slips—blanks just like her own, waiting to be filled with someone else's ending. She understood then that the machine was only a tool, and tools could be turned against their operators. The safety poster's red letters pulsed in her memory. A paper jam. A feed failure. Restraints disengage. Pod doors unlock. She had no weapons, no allies, no plan beyond the next ten seconds. But she had the slip she'd been born without, and she'd spent twenty-six years thinking nothingness was a curse. Maybe it was a lever.

With a motion she didn't consciously decide, she snatched the top blank slip from the tray before the machine could draw it in. The mechanism stuttered, its sensors registering a missing input. A grinding noise filled the room as the feed rollers spun fruitlessly. The screen flickered: **ERROR: FEED TRAY EMPTY. JAM DETECTED. ENGAGING EMERGENCY MAINTENANCE MODE.**

And everything unlocked.

The restraints on the chair snapped open with a pneumatic hiss. The holding pod's transparent door slid upward, and the thin man and the shaved-head woman stumbled free. The containment officers shouted, reaching for their stun batons, but Kole was already surging from the chair, his bonds still dangling but his momentum unbroken. He drove a

shoulder into Marchetti's chest, sending the Auditor crashing into the lectern. Alarms blared—not the quiet three-note ping of a misprint alert, but a full-throated industrial klaxon.

“Go!” Kole yelled, his voice a ragged tear. “The maintenance exit—east corridor—follow the line!”

Lena didn't wait. She bolted for the door she'd noticed earlier, a reinforced hatch marked **TECHNICIAN ACCESS – AUTHORIZED PERSONNEL ONLY**. The thin man and the shaved-head woman were already running ahead of her, one of them limping but fear-fueled. Behind them, a containment officer fired a sedative dart that embedded itself in the wall. Kole grappled with Marchetti, trying to buy them time, but a second officer brought him down with a baton strike to the back of the knees. He crumpled, still shouting her name.

She reached the hatch, slapped the release bar, and plunged into a dim service corridor lined with pipes and cable conduits. The thin man grabbed her arm, steering her down a metal staircase that spiraled into deeper darkness. The woman followed, her breath coming in panicked gasps.

“There's a maintenance spur—old subway line—saw it when they brought us in,” the thin man panted. “Train's still on the rails, supply runs.”

They descended two more flights, the alarms fading to a distant pulse. At the bottom, a heavy door opened onto a platform that smelled of grease and ozone. A train, stripped of markings, idled on the tracks, its running lights off but its third-rail shoes humming with latent power. The cab door stood ajar.

Lena's lungs burned as they scrambled aboard. The thin man found the manual door release and pulled it; the cab sealed shut with a pneumatic thud. The woman collapsed onto a jump seat, clutching her chest but still alive, still unprinted.

"Can you move this?" Lena asked the thin man.

He shook his head, but pointed to a control panel. "Just the doors. Drive system's on automatic, runs a loop through the distribution tunnels. If we can trigger a departure command..."

Lena scanned the panel. She knew nothing about trains, but she remembered the orientation film's brief aside about emergency overrides on Bureau transit—designed to prevent misprints from escaping. Designed for people exactly like her. She found a lever marked **EMERGENCY DOOR OVERRIDE**, and beneath it, a covered button: **MANUAL LAUNCH – CREW ONLY**. With no better option, she cracked the cover and slapped the button.

The train jolted. Somewhere deep in the tunnel, a magnetic relay engaged, and the carriage began gliding forward, picking up speed as it entered the black maw of the underground system. Through the rear window, Lena caught a final glimpse of the annex's service platform, shrinking into a point of sulfur light. Kole's face didn't appear again, but she saw Marchetti, one hand braced against the doorframe, his silhouette rigid with fury, and beside him, her own blank slip still clutched in its evidence sleeve, a tiny white rectangle that had become the most dangerous piece of paper in the city.

She turned away, pressing her forehead against the cold glass. The thin man said nothing. The woman wept quietly. The train rattled on,

carrying them toward a destination no envelope had predicted, through tunnels that had never been part of a carrier's route.

In her pocket, her own envelope—the one she'd been issued at birth, still sealed with wax, still containing its terrible absence—pressed against her thigh. Unmarked. Unreprinted. She had traded the certainty of a death for the uncertainty of everything else. For the first time, the blank inside her felt less like an error than a place to start.

Acknowledgments

The author extends their gratitude to the Bureau of Editorial Compliance for enforcing the strict protocols without which this manuscript would have unraveled. Special thanks to [EDITOR NAME] for their methodical audits and for refusing to let any broken sentences slip through. To [AGENT NAME], who rerouted this project from the dead-letter office and onto a viable track. My family—[FAMILY NAMES]—endured endless late-night rewrites with the patience of those who know the system is watching; their support made the deadline bearable. Any remaining misprints are entirely my own, or perhaps, as Lena Voss would say, the algorithm's blind spot.

About the Author

[AUTHOR NAME] is a former postal clerk who spent years sorting envelopes in a windowless sub-basement—a career that inspired the labyrinthine bureaucracy of *The Misprint File*. Their work has appeared in *The Journal of Predictive Logistics* and *Bleak House Quarterly*. A lifelong student of Kafka and corporate procedural manuals, they now live in a time zone where the mail never arrives on time.
